anything could happen and he wanted to make sure that it [the group] was really put on a solid foundation'.

Nohria quotes Ratan as saying, 'At some point I do think that you have a fiduciary responsibility as the largest shareholder of an entity. If you feel that you made a mistake in choosing the right leader and he may not be acting in a way that gives you confidence, then he would have to be replaced.'

Still, Ratan eschewed taking any unilateral decision and favoured the approach suggested by Nohria to give Mistry some more time. As Nohria recalls, had it not been for his advice, Mistry might have been asked to go sooner.

Ratan also wanted an independent assessment of Mistry's performance. The choice for the task again fell on Nohria. The dean reminisces that he was made the 'sounding board'. When Ratan was getting 'disenchanted', Nohria played the 'devil's advocate's role', and suggested 'that we should give him more time'. 'He was the moderator … he [Mistry] was under attack, but he actually delayed the action by six months or a year.'

Nohria assessed the performance of the conglomerate under Mistry. His conclusions were that though Mistry had several good qualities, he lacked the capability to steer a conglomerate as diverse as the Tatas. Mistry worked extremely hard; 'I would give him full marks on hard work'; he 'took his responsibility seriously' and was a 'very bright person', remarks Nohria. He states that this was the impression he gathered as a member of the Tata Sons board, which Mistry chaired. He was a 'good diagnostician', adds Nohria. But he had some serious downsides too.

Mistry was not a strong delegator. He had a penchant for doing everything himself. He could have selected 'twenty great leaders to get things done', but did not do so, opines Nohria. You 'can't run a company like this unless you have' a team of experts; 'one person cannot run the Tata Group', he says. R. Mukundan, MD Tata Chemicals, recalls that 'CM was a micro manager', and comments that 'if you get into details, you get overwhelmed' … as a 'leader, you have to delegate and get people to work'.

Mistry lacked the 'experience in running a large conglomerate, he didn't know how to work through people, he was probably more used to making decisions himself rather than working through other people', Nohria adds. He also did not choose his team well and 'surrounded himself with staff experts rather than with operating experts'. He also tended to procrastinate